



ing lubricating oils and fuel. Thus, we helped the industry members reduce their energy costs. Therefore, I got opportunities to study factory operations, processes, and systems in different sectors. My work profile used to involve interacting with senior-level business professionals.”

Besides great learning opportunities, Mahesh also had wonderful experiences out at IOCL because of his nice colleagues and supportive leadership. He reached the peak of his career within four years of joining IOCL.

The job provided Mahesh with all the comforts and fulfilled his family’s dream. It was a tough decision to come out of such a comfortable life of a secure high paying job and to start an uncertain entrepreneurial journey with high risk.

While explaining the situation, he says, “When I passed out, I did not have any vehicle in my home. My father never had a scooter. I bought a scooter immediately after getting the job and within six months I was able to buy my first car at the age of twenty-one. I was also able to arrange a comfortable and good lifestyle for my family because of that job.”

However, he did not remain confined to the stereotype of “continuing a high-paying stable job in a public sector unit” and willingly left that comfort to follow his entrepreneurial dream. While describing the same, he mentions, “My inner self asked me what I was doing at IOCL? I was quite convinced that continuing with a secure job was not the right thing for me. I felt the need to work and give back more to society and that I must innovate.”

Therefore, he set out on his entrepreneurial journey and established his first venture SS Appliances Private Limited in 1988. It was a pureplay bootstrap startup as he says, “I purchased the factory by paying two and a half lakh rupees



*Mahesh Gupta, Chairman, Kent RO Systems, receiving the award from Jai Prakash Narayan Yadav, Hon'ble Union Minister of State for Water Resources*

(₹250,000), which I got from my provident fund savings.”

He discloses, “In the initial days, starting from clerk, project manager to typist, I was everything for my company. I started my first company, truly a ‘Make in India’ startup, with my savings from the provident fund. I have never borrowed even a single rupee from anybody in my life. Even today, we have no history of borrowing at all. We are a debt-free company. I never intend to borrow either. I work with whatever money I have.”

Mahesh’s first invention was in the field of petroleum conservation instruments where he earned fame and half a dozen patents to his credit. He remembers, “We launched viscosity meters. People used to go to laboratories to get their oil quality tested. Our product was able to do the same instantaneously and they could decide to change oil accordingly.” That company is running with profit to date with a diversified product portfolio, including oil flow meters.

While discussing his entrepreneurial journey, he says, “I started the business for a bigger cause and

slowly things started unfolding in my life. I always believe in value addition. My products became popular, and I started earning money because those added value to my customers. The price of my products depends on the value addition and innovation, not on the formula of cost.”

With the same vision of adding value to the customers while contributing towards a greener, cleaner, and healthier world, Mahesh started his consumer appliance venture. He says, “In 1998, my children fell ill and I became aware of the fact that 80% of diseases in India are caused by water-borne microorganisms and that 80% of urban families do not even purify tap water. I decided to install a water purifier at my Delhi home, but I was disappointed with the available options. The water purifiers available in the market in those days worked on ultraviolet (UV) technology, which kills bacteria in the water. I knew this was not good enough since the water we drink also contains many dissolved impurities, which cannot be treated with this technology. I wanted to develop a water purifier that would